THE LINE

ONE-HOUR CRIME THRILLER • 8 EPISODES • ATLANTA

"When you don't own what you built, how far will you go to take it back?"

LOGLINE

After an assassination attempt exposes the criminal machinery beneath her Atlanta music empire, ambitious music executive **Monique "Mo" Sanders** is forced into an uneasy alliance with **Tom Whitaker**, an FBI agent posing as her head of security. Together they uncover a conspiracy connecting Atlanta's music business, organized crime, law enforcement, and Mo's own family, including evidence that the catalog she inherited from her dying father may have been stolen through a fraudulent deal.

THE SERIES

THE LINE is a propulsive Atlanta crime thriller set at the intersection of hip-hop, money, family and institutional power.

Monique Sanders has spent eight years transforming her late father's struggling label, MSMG, into a rising force in Atlanta music. She believes she's finally escaped the streets that consumed her family.

Then somebody tries to kill her.

The FBI quietly embeds disgraced but formidable agent Tom Whitaker inside MSMG as Mo's new security chief. His target is Dexter Miles, a polished criminal power broker whose organization has quietly embedded itself in Atlanta's music economy through predatory contracts, shell companies and publishing rights.

But Mo soon discovers something more devastating than Dexter's criminal operation:

> *Dexter already owns sixty percent of the music empire she thought belonged to her.*

The trail leads back to 2017, when her father Philip was dying and her uncle Lyle Sanders made a desperate deal to keep the company alive. A missing contract schedule, suspicious signatures and medical records raise an even darker possibility:

> *Philip Sanders may never have signed his catalog away at all.*

Now Mo and Tom are fighting the same enemy for very different reasons. Tom needs Mo to penetrate Dexter's organization. Mo needs Tom to help uncover who stole her father's legacy.

And neither knows whether the greatest threat is outside MSMG… or already inside the family.

THE ENGINE

Every episode pushes two investigations toward collision.

TOM — OUTWARD

Follows the criminal conspiracy outward: Dexter's money, shooters, shell corporations, corrupt officials, and the larger organization operating above him.

MO — INWARD

Follows the family conspiracy inward: her father's catalog, the missing Schedule B, her imprisoned brother Sandy's secret FBI connection, and what Lyle really did in 2017.

Meanwhile, Mo begins quietly building a clean catalog — a financial lifeboat designed to protect her artists from Dexter's ownership structure.

The deeper Tom and Mo go, the more dangerous the central question becomes:

> *Where is the line between protecting someone and using them?*

MONIQUE "MO" SANDERS | 32

Music Executive. Survivor. Heir to an empire she may not actually own.

Brilliant, ambitious and Atlanta-born, Mo can read a contract, a room and a threat before most people realize one exists. She built MSMG into something her father would have recognized as a legacy. Discovering that Dexter has quietly profited from everything she's created turns survival into war.

Mo isn't Tom's protected asset. She's his partner — whether the FBI likes it or not.

TOM WHITAKER | 42

FBI Agent. Protector. A man carrying one dead asset too many.

Former military intelligence turned FBI field operative, Tom comes to Atlanta carrying the stain of a disastrous Dallas operation that left a civilian asset dead. His assignment is simple: infiltrate MSMG as Mo's security chief, keep her alive, and use her access to reach Dexter.

Then Tom starts caring whether Mo survives for reasons that aren't in his case file.

LYLE SANDERS | 60S

Uncle. Protector. Keeper of the original sin.

Lyle helped raise Mo and kept her father's company alive when it was collapsing. Mo sees him as family, mentor, and the man who preserved her inheritance.

Dexter tells a different story. And Lyle's secret ledger, his mysterious contact known only as "R," and his knowledge of the missing contract documents suggest he has spent eight years protecting far more than Mo.

DEXTER MILES | 40S

Criminal entrepreneur. Music power broker. The man who already owns the board.

Dexter doesn't need to kick down doors — he owns the paper behind them. Sophisticated, patient and frighteningly informed, Dexter has turned contracts, publishing rights and financial leverage into weapons as effective as guns.

His greatest advantage is simple: everyone thinks they're playing against him before realizing they're already playing for him.

TONE + WORLD

> *BODYGUARD × SNOWFALL × THE WIRE — with the music-industry power dynamics of EMPIRE, grounded as a contemporary serialized crime thriller.*

Atlanta isn't scenery. It's infrastructure. Studios. Nightclubs. Federal offices. Legacy Black businesses. Buckhead money. Midtown law firms. Street economies. New Atlanta colliding with old Atlanta.

Music drives the world without turning the series into a musical. Every track has artistic value, cultural value and, critically, ownership value.

The soundtrack becomes part of the storytelling — and a commercial extension of the series.

THEMES

OWNERSHIP | TRUST | LEGACY | SURVIVAL | REDEMPTION

—Who owns the art?

—Who owns the business?

—Who owns the truth?

—What happens when the people who claim to be protecting you have secretly been making decisions for you?

At its heart, THE LINE is about two people who have stopped trusting institutions learning, very cautiously, to trust each other.

WHY IT SELLS

THE LINE combines an accessible thriller engine with a world television rarely explores from this angle: the economics behind Atlanta's music culture.

The pilot delivers assassination attempts, undercover FBI operations and organized crime — but its distinctive weapon is ownership. Publishing contracts, royalty streams and catalogs become instruments of power.

That gives the series multiple commercial lanes: a serialized crime mystery, action thriller, family drama, music-industry drama, premium soundtrack opportunities, emerging-artist integration, and a strong central two-hander.

> *Season One contains a clean binge question: who stole Philip Sanders' legacy, and what will Mo have to become to take it back?*

The Room

The casting list below reflects the rewritten pilot, not the original pitch. In particular: Mo is now 32, Dexter has become considerably more sophisticated, and Lyle requires an actor who can make us love him while simultaneously making us wonder whether he's capable of something terrible.

Four roles, each with a first choice and ranked alternates, followed by two assembled packages — a prestige version and a commercial/music-forward version — and the pairing the show is actually built to live or die on.

> *Bernthal + Fishback: two people who'd irritate the hell out of each other, save each other's lives, distrust each other's institutions, and eventually realize the other person may be the only one in Atlanta telling them the truth.*

TOM WHITAKER

FBI Agent · 42

JB

Jon Bernthal FIRST CHOICE

Still the strongest choice. He naturally gives Tom the thing the character needs most: contained violence. You believe he can walk quietly through MSMG for twenty minutes and then put two rounds through a four-inch opening without changing expression.

JK

Joel Kinnaman ALTERNATE

The strongest premium-thriller alternative, especially for Tom's military/FBI history and emotional reserve.

JD

Josh Duhamel ALTERNATE

Pushes Tom toward classic network-leading-man territory and broadens the procedural accessibility.

RANKING: BERNTHAL → KINNAMAN → DUHAMEL

MONIQUE "MO" SANDERS

Music Executive · 32

DF

Dominique Fishback — FIRST CHOICE

The rewritten Mo needs enormous intelligence behind the eyes. Fishback can make Mo's silences active — and some of her strongest moments involve realizing that someone she trusts has lied to her.

KP

Keke Palmer — COMMERCIAL FIRST CHOICE

Changes the package: star power, music credibility, humor, cultural recognition and marketing firepower. Makes Mo louder and more charismatic than Fishback's interpretation — not necessarily a drawback.

RD

Ryan Destiny — BREAKOUT / YOUNGER GLAMOUR

Gives MSMG immediate music-industry authenticity and leans into Mo's executive glamour.

RANKING: FISHBACK (PRESTIGE) → PALMER (COMMERCIAL PACKAGING) → DESTINY (MUSIC-WORLD HEAT)

LYLE SANDERS

Uncle · 60s · This role has become much more important

WP

Wendell Pierce — FIRST CHOICE

Almost tailor-made for the rewrite. Warmth, authority, history and moral ambiguity. Most importantly, an audience would trust him — which makes the possibility of betrayal hurt.

CV

Courtney B. Vance — PRESTIGE ALTERNATIVE

Would make Lyle's intelligence more visible and the 2017 mystery potentially darker.

CP

Clifton Powell — ATLANTA / GENRE AUTHENTICITY

Gives Lyle a harder street history immediately.

RANKING: PIERCE → VANCE → POWELL

DEXTER MILES

Power Broker · 40s · A potential breakout antagonist

SB

Sterling K. Brown FIRST CHOICE

Against expected type — and lethal for it. Dexter isn't a stereotypical gangster; he's articulate, financially sophisticated and completely comfortable around power. Brown could make the cigar-alley conversation terrifying without raising his voice.

CD

Colman Domingo ALTERNATE

If Dexter is aged slightly, Domingo could turn him into an extraordinary Atlanta kingmaker — elegant, charismatic, dangerous.

TR

Trevante Rhodes HARDER ALTERNATIVE

Younger and more physically imposing — a different Dexter: less patriarch, more contemporary mogul.

RANKING: BROWN → DOMINGO → RHODES

Note: Rhodes moves from the original Dexter Miles casting slot into consideration for Dexter himself — the rewritten role deserves serious casting capital.

THE PACKAGE I'D TAKE INTO A ROOM

PRESTIGE VERSION

Jon Bernthal · Dominique Fishback

Wendell Pierce · Sterling K. Brown

That's a serious ensemble.

COMMERCIAL / MUSIC-FORWARD VERSION

Josh Duhamel · Keke Palmer

Clifton Powell · Trevante Rhodes

Two different versions of the same property.

But the dream pairing remains **Bernthal + Fishback**, because the show lives or dies on Tom and Mo having chemistry that isn't immediately romantic. They should look like two people who would irritate the hell out of each other, save each other's lives, distrust each other's institutions, and eventually realize the other person may be the only one in Atlanta telling them the truth.

THE LINE

"Everybody owns a piece. Nobody owns the truth."